

A CLOSER LOOK

Packing your bag

By the time you reach 36 weeks, prepare supplies for the birth itself, since you might go into labor at any point. Whether you intend to give birth in the hospital or at a birthing center, you'll need a few essential items for labor, and the equivalent of an overnight bag with extras for you and your baby after the birth. Ask about any stipulations your hospital may have about what you can and can't bring with you, and consider packing items for your birth partner, too. Lastly, don't forget your birth plan!

Healthy snacks Most hospitals won't let you eat or drink when you check in and when you are in labor, but pack a stash of healthy snacks like fruit and cereal bars to keep your partner energized and hydrated during labor.

You will want a few toiletries for before and after the birth. Lips can get dry in labor, so a lip balm will be welcome, and a face spray or washcloth that you can wet will be refreshing and soothing during labor.

If you've had stitches, those first toilet trips can sting! Pack a small plastic pitcher, or an old plastic water bottle, so you can pour warm water over your perineal area as you urinate.

Comfort aids You might want a couple of home pillows for extra comfort, and an exercise ball if the hospital doesn't supply them. And remember to pack any other aids for labor, such as massage oil, a back massager or your favorite slippers.

Your things for after the birth You will need old underwear or disposable underwear and maternity sanitary pads for postpartum bleeding. A nursing bra, breast pads, burp cloths, and nipple cream will provide all you need to start breast-feeding. Pack some night wear, flip-flops, and some loose clothing for leaving the hospital.

